"Khitan tribal elements [and] assimilated Chinese features" even as they ruled over a majority Muslim population comprising vassals and citizenry. In the eyes of their subject populations in Transoxiana and those farther east, Qarakhitay legitimacy was associated with the "high civilization" of China. Even though the region comprising this civilization was a concept often devoid of geographical and demographic accuracy, it behooved the Qarakhitay to maintain their eastern *loci* of aspirations: their imperial domains lay at the intersection of Persianate and Sinicizing ecumenes, throughout which such a projection of kingly personas was legible, effective, and accepted.[27]

During the twelfth century, the Yamini-Ghaznavids' (*c.* 998–1186 CE) instability attracted politico-military rivals into the pivotal region now bounded by modern Afghanistan. For the Ghaznavids, their core holdings in Zabulistan, al-Rukkhaj, and Zamindawar (map, p. xv) had collectively served as a springboard both toward the west, deep into Khurasan, as well as the east, to the Indus valleys and the north Indian plains. Thus, these core holdings were both strategically and commercially desirable (cf. Chapter 5). They were also where the Shansabanis were emerging as a local power and carving out the beginnings of their own imperium, embroiled in a long and fractious relationship with the Ghaznavids (see below and Chapters 2 and 3). The Shansabanis' rise in the fourth through eighth decades of the twelfth century also instigated confrontations with the Saljuqs (tenth–mid-twelfth centuries) as the latter sought suzerainty over the smaller polities on their eastern frontiers (cf. below), and the Khwarazm-shahs (twelfth–thirteenth centuries) and Qarakhanids (tenth–early thirteenth centuries), who were also attempting territorial expansion.[28] Afghanistan, then, was the canvas upon which the trajectories of the Persianate ecumene's major empires – which eventually included the Shansabanis – intertwined throughout the twelfth century.[29]

Although on quite different geographical scales, the spectacular debut of Saljuq power in the Persianate world during the eleventh century, and the meteoric rise of the Shansabanis in the twelfth, evince fascinating historical and historiographical parallels. Most significantly, the Saljuqs and Shansabanis were interlopers, entering from "outside" the elite Perso-Islamic prestige cultures they subsequently deployed toward kingship. The Saljuqs' Turkic *ethnie* and earliest associations with the territories of the tenth-century Khazars (in modern west Kazakhstan) were not their only exogenous characteristics; the principles of socio-political organization and the many cultural traditions arising from their nomadic life-world also rendered them largely "other" to the Persianate regions they came to dominate.[30]

The Shansabanis' ethnic and geographical origins technically lay *within* this Persianate world: their *ethnie* is generally thought to have derived from Iranian–Tajik populations[31]; and one could conceive of Ghur's geography